PHOTOS THAT SELL

BONUS 6



Photos That Sell: Phone Photography for Jewelry

How to photograph tiny beadwork with the phone in your pocket, so buyers can see every bead

You can stitch the most beautiful bracelet in the world, and if the photo looks dim, blurry or crowded, it will sit unseen. Online, the photo is the product. A buyer cannot touch your work, feel its weight or hold it up to the light. All they have is the picture, and a good picture does the job of a shop window.

The good news is that you do not need a camera, a studio or a course. A recent phone, a window, and a few cheap tricks are enough to make delicate beadwork look as lovely as it does in your hands. This guide walks you through light, backgrounds, angles, settings, free editing, sizes, descriptions, and a 20-shot checklist you can follow every time.

One note before we begin. Apps, phone menus and marketplace image rules change often, so wherever we mention exact settings or sizes, check the current recommendations in your own app or on the platform's help pages.

1. Chapter 1: Light Is Everything

Photographers say light is more than half of a good photo, and with tiny beadwork it is closer to nine tenths. Seed beads are small, glossy and often metallic, which means harsh light creates hot white spots and deep shadows between the beads, and dim light creates grainy, muddy colors. Soft, even light makes every bead readable.

There are two simple ways to get it. The first is natural window light. Set up a table next to a bright window, not in direct sunbeams, and place your piece where the light falls softly on it. Overcast days are wonderful for this, because the clouds act as a giant softbox. If the sun is strong, hang a sheer curtain or a sheet of plain white paper over the glass to soften it.

The second is a lightbox, which is a small enclosure with white walls and light coming in from the sides or top. It gives you the same soft light on any day and any hour, so your photos look alike all year. Craft and photography stores sell small folding ones, but you can make a good one at home for well under $15.

> **DIY LIGHTBOX FOR UNDER $15 (EXAMPLE COSTS)**
>
> You need: a medium cardboard box (free), white poster board or printer paper (a few dollars), tape or glue, a craft knife or scissors, white tissue paper or a thin white cloth (a couple of dollars), and one or two daylight-style LED desk lamps if you have them (a small bulb may be cheaper than a lamp). Cut a large window in the top and in each side of the box, leaving a frame of cardboard. Tape tissue paper over the windows to diffuse the light. Line the inside with white poster board in a smooth curve so there are no hard corners. Place the lamps outside the top and side windows. Prices vary, so check your local store.

- Use window light for a natural, airy look, and a lightbox for consistency.
- Avoid overhead room lights and a flash, which flatten the piece and cause glare.
- Do not mix warm yellow bulbs with daylight; it confuses your phone's color.
- Keep the light soft: if you can see a crisp shadow edge, the light is too harsh.

Practice task: find your best spot

Place one finished piece on a white sheet near a window. Take one photo in each of three places: right at the window, two feet back, and in a darker corner. Compare them on a computer or large screen. Pick the spot where the colors look the truest and the shadows are the softest. That is your photo station.

2. Chapter 2: Backgrounds That Flatter Delicate Beadwork

Delicate beadwork needs a background that supports it without competing. The best backgrounds are quiet, plain and slightly textured, so the eye goes straight to your beads. A busy tablecloth or a patterned scarf may look charming in person but in a photo it hides the pattern you worked so hard on.

Choose your background by contrast. Light, pastel or white beadwork pops against a mid or dark neutral. Dark, jewel-tone or metallic beadwork shines on white, cream or soft gray. If your piece contains many colors, use a neutral that appears in none of them.

Background	Best for	Watch out for
Plain white paper or poster board	Dark and colorful pieces; marketplace main images	Can look cold or gray if the light is dim; keep it flat and clean
Warm cream or linen fabric	Soft, earthy or pastel designs	Wrinkles show in photos; iron or smooth it flat
Light gray card	Metallic and shimmer finishes	Check that it does not tint the colors
Dark slate or charcoal card	White, pearl and pale pieces	Dust and lint show easily; wipe it first
Wood board, light or mid tone	Lifestyle shots with a handmade feel	Strong grain can compete with fine patterns
Matte paper or fabric in a single muted color	Matching your shop's brand look	Avoid shiny surfaces that reflect the beads

Matte surfaces beat glossy ones almost every time. Shiny glass, polished tables and laminated cards mirror your piece and add distracting reflections. If you only have a glossy table, cover it with a sheet of paper or a flat piece of fabric.

Display matters too. A bracelet lying flat looks fine, but a bracelet curled gently on a small roll of fabric or a simple stand shows its shape. Earrings look best hanging from a card, a small stand, or lying together as a pair on a clean surface. Keep props few: one sprig of dried flowers or a small ceramic dish is enough. If you wonder whether a prop belongs, take it out.

> **CLEAN BEFORE YOU SHOOT**
>
> Phone cameras are merciless with dust, lint and pet hair. Wipe your background, brush your piece gently with a soft makeup brush, and clean the camera lens with a soft cloth. A smudged lens is the most common reason for a hazy, dreamy-but-blurry photo.

3. Chapter 3: Angles and the Shot List

A single photo cannot sell a piece. Buyers want to see the whole item, then a detail, then how big it is, then how it looks in real life. Think of each listing as a short visual story, told in five types of shots: hero, detail, scale, lifestyle and packaging.

Shot	What it shows	How to take it
Hero	The whole piece, clean and centered; this is your first and most important image	Soft light, plain background, camera directly above or at a slight angle, piece fills most of the frame
Detail	Close-up of the stitch, texture and finish	Move the phone closer or use the zoom lens at 2x, hold steady, tap to focus on the beads
Scale	How big the piece is	Place beside a coin, a ruler or a hand; state the measurements in the listing too
Lifestyle	The piece worn or styled in a real setting	Soft daylight, simple outfit or hand shot, natural pose
Packaging	What the buyer receives	Show the box or bag, a card, and the piece nested inside

Angles change the feeling of a photo. Shooting straight down from above, called a flat lay, is the easiest and the most consistent for flat pieces like bracelets, bookmarks and pendants. A slight angle of about 30 to 45 degrees gives depth and shows the texture of the stitches. A very low angle works well for earrings hanging from a stand. Try each, then keep the one you like and repeat it.

Fill the frame. Many beginners leave too much empty space around the piece, so it appears tiny when the image shrinks to a thumbnail. As a rule, the item should take up the majority of the frame in your hero image, while still leaving a small margin for cropping later.

- Hero: one clear, full view.
- Back or clasp view: show how it closes.
- Two or three details: the stitch pattern, the edge, the finish.
- Scale: next to a coin or ruler.
- On-body or lifestyle: how it looks worn.
- Packaging: what arrives in the mail.

Practice task: tell the story in six photos

Choose one finished piece and take six photos: hero, back or clasp, two details, scale and packaging. Lay them out on your phone's screen next to each other. Do they tell a complete story? If a buyer saw only these six, could they judge size, quality and what arrives? Retake whichever one weakens the set.

4. Chapter 4: Phone Settings That Matter

Your phone's camera is powerful, and a handful of simple settings unlock the best of it. Menus and names differ between phone models and software versions, so look for the equivalent options on your own device.

- Clean the lens before every session. It is the single biggest improvement for zero cost.
- Turn the flash off. Flash causes glare and flattens the glossy surface of seed beads.
- Turn on the grid lines in your camera settings. They help you keep the piece level and centered.
- Use the standard (1x) or 2x lens for close shots rather than digital zoom, which reduces quality.
- Switch off heavy beauty or filter modes. You want true colors.
- If your phone offers a high-resolution or high-efficiency format, choose a setting that gives you a sharp, large file, and check which format your editing app and marketplace accept.
- Use portrait mode with caution. It can blur the edges of fine beadwork by mistake.

Stability is the quiet hero of sharp photos. Even a tiny wobble blurs seed beads, because each bead is so small. Rest your elbows on the table, hold your breath as you tap the shutter, or better yet use a cheap phone tripod or a stack of books. Many phones offer a self-timer of two or three seconds, which lets you tap the screen and let go before the photo is taken.

> **MACRO TIP FOR CLOSE-UPS**
>
> Many phones can focus very close up, but the lens can struggle if you hold it too near the piece. If the picture will not sharpen, back the phone away a few inches and zoom or crop afterward. A little distance often gives a crisper result than pressing right up to the beads.

Take more photos than you need. Shoot ten of each angle, then choose the sharpest. Digital storage is cheap, and a single sharp shot among many blurry ones is easy to miss unless you look closely. Zoom in on each image on your screen to check that the individual beads are in focus before you delete the rest.

5. Chapter 5: Focus and Exposure

Two things decide whether a photo looks professional: focus, which is whether your beads are sharp, and exposure, which is how bright or dark the picture is. Both are easy to control on any phone by tapping the screen.

To set focus, tap the screen exactly where you want things sharpest, usually the center of the piece or the most important detail. A small box or circle appears. Wait for it to settle before you take the shot. For close-ups, tap on a bead that sits at the very front of the piece, not the background.

To adjust exposure, most phones let you slide a small sun icon or a similar control up or down after tapping. Slide up slightly if the picture looks dim, and slide down if bright areas turn into plain white. Pay special attention to white, pearl and metallic beads, which can lose all their detail if the picture is too bright. It is easier to brighten a slightly dark photo than to rescue a washed-out one.

Problem you see	Likely cause	Quick fix
Beads look soft or fuzzy	Camera shake or focus on the background	Use a tripod or timer; tap on the beads to refocus
White spots on shiny beads	Harsh light or flash	Move to softer light; turn off flash; diffuse with a sheet
Photo looks gray and dull	Underexposed or dim room	Move closer to the window; raise exposure slightly
Colors look yellow or blue	Mixed lighting or odd white balance	Use one light source only; correct color in editing
Edges of the piece look blurry while the center is sharp	Piece not flat or shallow depth of field	Step back, flatten the piece, or take from straight above

Color is a promise to your buyer. If the photo shows soft sage and the bracelet arrives gray-green, you will earn a return or a poor review. Shoot in consistent light, check your color on more than one screen if you can, and describe the color in words as well as in the picture.

Practice task: the exposure ladder

Take three photos of the same piece, one a touch dark, one normal, and one a touch bright, by tapping and sliding the exposure control. View them side by side and decide which shows both the lightest and darkest beads clearly. Notice how your phone behaves and use that setting as your starting point from now on.

6. Chapter 6: Editing with Free Apps

A light edit takes a good photo and makes it a great one. The goal is not to change your piece, but to show it as it looks in real life. Think of editing as cleaning the window, not repainting the view. If you can tell a photo has been heavily edited, it has probably gone too far.

You do not need to pay for software. Free options include the editor built into your phone's photo app, Snapseed, and the free version of Lightroom mobile. App features and what is free can change, so check each app's current offerings. All of them can handle the basic steps below.

Tool	Good for	Notes
Built-in phone photo editor	Quick crop, brightness and contrast	Already on your phone; ideal for beginners
Snapseed	Selective adjustments, healing spots and dust, perspective fixes	Free app; offers more control for fine details
Lightroom mobile (free version)	Consistent color and presets across many photos	Check which features are included in the free tier

Follow the same order every time so your results stay consistent. First crop and straighten. Second, adjust brightness gently. Third, adjust contrast slightly. Fourth, correct white balance (the warm-to-cool setting) until whites look white. Fifth, nudge saturation or vibrance only a little, if at all. Last, sharpen very lightly. Zoom in to check the result at full size.

- Crop and straighten first.
- Raise brightness a little if the photo looks dim.
- Add slight contrast for depth, not drama.
- Fix white balance until a white page looks white.
- Raise saturation only slightly; never change the color of the beads.
- Sharpen lightly, then check the image at full size.
- Remove dust spots with a heal or retouch tool.

> **NEVER EDIT THE TRUTH**
> Do not change the actual color, pattern or size of your piece. Editing is for light, clarity and tidiness. If a buyer receives something that looks different from the listing, it costs you the sale and the trust. Retake the photo rather than faking it.

Once you find an edit you like, save it as a preset or note the exact steps, then apply it to every photo in the set. Consistency is what makes a shop look professional.

7. Chapter 7: A Consistent Look, Sizes, and Words

Shoppers browse by thumbnail. When your listings share the same background, light and framing, your shop looks like a brand instead of a random collection. Choose one background and one editing style, and stick to them. You can vary the lifestyle shots, but keep the hero images uniform.

Image size is the technical part. Each platform sets its own recommended dimensions and file limits, and these change from time to time, so check current recommended sizes on the platform's help pages before you upload. As general guidance, use the highest quality that the platform allows, keep the file in a common format such as JPG or PNG, and leave a margin around your piece so it does not get cut off when the platform crops its thumbnails. Square or near-square images are a flexible starting point, because they crop safely in many places.

Where it appears	What to do
Etsy or similar marketplace listing	Check current recommended sizes and the number of images allowed; make the first image the hero and keep the item centered
Instagram feed post	Check current recommended sizes and ratios; square or portrait often works; keep the piece away from the edges
Instagram Stories or Reels cover	Check current recommended sizes; keep key content away from the top and bottom edges where the app places buttons
Your own website or shop page	Use consistent dimensions across all products so the grid looks tidy

Words help photos work harder. Search engines and screen readers cannot see your picture, but they can read what you say about it. Alt text is a short written description of an image, used by people who rely on screen readers and by search engines. Write it plainly, as though describing the photo to a friend on the phone. A good example: 'Pastel peyote stitch bracelet in blush pink and cream seed beads on a white linen background.' Keep it factual and short, and avoid stuffing it with keywords.

> **LISTING TITLES THAT HELP BUYERS FIND YOU**
>
> Lead with the words a buyer would actually type, then add what makes your piece special. A clear structure is: what it is, the main material, the main color or style, and who or what it suits. For example: 'Beaded bracelet, Japanese seed beads, blush and cream, delicate gift for her.' Avoid repeating the same word many times, and put the most important words first, since titles are often cut off in search results. Check each platform's current title rules.

Finally, keep your descriptions honest and specific. Mention the length or size in inches and centimeters, the materials, the clasp type, and how to care for the piece. Clear details mean fewer questions and fewer returns.

8. Chapter 8: The 20-Shot Checklist and Common Mistakes

Here is your master checklist. You will not need all twenty images for every listing, but running through the list in a single session means you will never have to set up your station again for the same piece. Use the best of each category for listings and social posts.

- 1. Hero, full piece, flat lay from above.
- 2. Hero, slight angle at 30 to 45 degrees.
- 3. Hero on a light background.
- 4. Hero on a dark background.
- 5. Close-up of the stitch pattern.
- 6. Close-up of the edge or finish.
- 7. Close-up of the clasp or ear wire.
- 8. Back of the piece.
- 9. Piece coiled or curved to show shape.
- 10. Scale shot next to a coin or ruler.
- 11. Scale shot in a hand or on a wrist.
- 12. Worn or styled, close.
- 13. Worn or styled, wider with an outfit.
- 14. Natural-light lifestyle shot with a simple prop.
- 15. Pair of earrings together on a flat surface.
- 16. Matching set shown together, if you make sets.
- 17. Color-accuracy shot near a window, with a white card for reference.
- 18. Packaging closed.
- 19. Packaging open with the piece nested inside.
- 20. Handwritten card or care note beside the package (without contact details).

Now, the mistakes. Almost every beginner makes the same ones, and each is easy to fix once you know it.

Common mistake	Why it hurts	The fix
Using flash or overhead room light	Harsh glare and flat color	Use window light or a lightbox
Busy or patterned background	Hides the beadwork	Switch to a plain, matte surface
Photographing from too far away	Piece looks tiny and details vanish	Fill the frame; crop in editing
Only one photo per listing	Buyers cannot judge size or quality	Use the hero, detail, scale, lifestyle and packaging set
Blurry close-ups	Looks careless and hides the stitch	Use a tripod or timer; tap to focus
Over-editing colors	Piece arrives looking different	Edit light and clarity, not color
Inconsistent look across listings	Shop feels random and less trustworthy	Use one background and one edit style

8. Chapter 8: The 20-Shot Checklist and Common Mistakes (continued)

YOUR 10-MINUTE ROUTINE

Clean the lens. Set up the background by the window. Place the piece and brush off dust. Take the hero shots first, then details, scale, and lifestyle. Review for sharpness, delete the blurry ones, apply your saved edit, and name your files clearly so you can find them later. Repeat the same routine every time.

Practice task: shoot a full set

Choose one finished piece and work through all twenty shots in one session, timing yourself. Pick your best six for a listing and your best three for social posts. Note how long it took and what slowed you down. Next time, fix the slowest step first, and you will soon have a quick routine you can repeat for every new piece.

Next steps

Great product photos are not about expensive gear. They are about soft light, a quiet background, a steady hand, honest color and a repeatable routine. Practice with one piece, learn what your phone does best, and save your favorite settings and edit so the next session takes minutes.

Remember to check the current recommended image sizes and rules on any platform before you upload. Your beadwork took hours of patient work, and now you have the tools to show it at its best. From all of us at Tiny Bead Studio, happy stitching and happy shooting.

20-shot checklist

Run through it for each new design.

	Shot
☐	Hero shot on a clean background
☐	Close-up of the stitching
☐	Scale shot (on a wrist or ear)
☐	Back/clasp detail
☐	Flat lay with packaging
☐	Lifestyle shot (worn)
☐	Color variations side by side
☐	Detail of the finish
☐	Tag and branding
☐	Gift-box opening shot
☐	Hero shot on a clean background
☐	Close-up of the stitching
☐	Scale shot (on a wrist or ear)
☐	Back/clasp detail
☐	Flat lay with packaging
☐	Lifestyle shot (worn)
☐	Color variations side by side
☐	Detail of the finish
☐	Tag and branding
☐	Gift-box opening shot